

U.S. ATTACKED

Hijacked Planes Destroy Trade Towers, Hit Pentagon; Thousands Feared Dead



Fire and smoke engulf the towers of the World Trade Center in New York City after commercial jetliners hit the building. Both towers collapsed shortly after. SPENCER PLATT / Getty Images

Magnitude of tragedy unfolds in lost lives

One of the victims was a pilot from Bucks County. "Pray for them," his father-in-law said.

By Matthew P. Blanchard and Kayce T. Ataiyero
INQUIRER SUBURBAN STAFF

Victor Saracini was a self-made man, working his way up from Navy pilot to United Airlines captain, and settling with his wife and two daughters in an affluent Bucks County community.

His life ended yesterday. Saracini, 51, was commander of the second commercial jet to crash into the World Trade Center while a disbelieving

world watched live on television.

Lower Makefield resident Saracini was among the first of what will likely be hundreds and perhaps thousands of victims, including 266 passengers and crew aboard four hijacked flights, to be identified in the days and weeks to come.

"Pray for them," said Saracini's father-in-law, Bernard G. Hildebrand. "Pray for them all."

Across the nation, people with friends and family working in the financial nerve center of Lower Manhattan, at the Pentagon, or traveling cross-country for business spent yesterday. See **PILOT** on A17



Pedestrians run from the World Trade Center area as the first of the twin towers collapses. All tunnels and bridges into Manhattan were closed yesterday. PAUL HAWTHORNE / Associated Press

Bush vows justice will be sweeping

By Ralph Vigoda
INQUIRER STAFF WRITER

A series of near-precision assaults shattered two symbols of America's military and financial power yesterday, killing untold numbers of people, halting Americans' daily routine, and forever destroying a nation's feeling that it can't happen here.

Within minutes at the start of the workday, unidentified terrorists hijacked two commercial jets and plunged them into the twin towers of New York's World Trade Center — reducing the 110-story landmarks to rubble and sending some workers leaping out windows — then crashed a third jet into the Pentagon outside Washington. A fourth hijacked plane, possibly also diverted toward the Washington area, crashed in Somerset County in Western Pennsylvania.

The terrorists' audacity was matched by the stunning coordination of their operation — all four planes had left three airports within 12 minutes of one another — and experts scrambled to start investigating how they had bypassed security and pulled it off. U.S. officials said they had had no reports that the attacks were imminent and can expect questions about the breakdown in intelligence.

The carnage seemed destined to stand as the worst attack on civilians in U.S. history. The death toll — which could take days, even weeks, to emerge — was likely to be far more catastrophic than the 2,400 killed nearly 60 years ago in the surprise bombing at Pearl Harbor.

Emergency workers at the World Trade Center site in Lower Manhattan faced a gruesome, blazing scene.

"There were bodies everywhere, body parts everywhere," said Angelo Otchy, a National Guardsman from See **ATTACK** on A14

In seconds, a confident N.Y. is shaken

By Alfred Lubrano
INQUIRER STAFF WRITER

Life changed fast and forever yesterday morning, when an unseen terrorist hand guided two planes into the twin towers of the World Trade Center, collapsing the symbols of New York City's commercial and cultural greatness.

Now there is smoke where there once was steel, shocked silence where a self-assured populace once ran America's most dynamic city.

Casualties were expected to be in the thousands, as the attack rocked what amounts to two vertical cities.

By nightfall, an unsettling quiet permeated Lower Manhattan from Soho, to Chinatown, to Greenwich Village.

Two inches of white ash had snowed onto the streets, muffling noise like a blizzard, giving a savage day a surreal end.

"It's like Pompeii," a Battery Park City doorman said, as though only an See **CITY** on A8